
From Pyramid Town to Provincial Necropolis: Sources and Networks in Middle Kingdom Egypt

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Abstract

The reconstruction of social networks in Egyptology depends fundamentally on the nature of the available sources (Stefanović 2024a). Administrative archives and funerary monuments do not simply document social relations in different ways - they produce structurally different networks. This paper argues that the contrast between different categories of sources is not a limitation but a methodological resource for historical network analysis.

The study compares two contemporaneous contexts from the late Middle Kingdom and early Second Intermediate Period (mid-2nd millennium BC): the pyramid town of Lahun in the Fayum and the provincial necropolis of Elkab in Upper Egypt. At Lahun, administrative papyri and associated archaeological material provide dense prosopographical data on officials, dependents, and households (Quirke 2005; Stefanović 2024b). These sources enable the reconstruction of multi-layered networks linking administrative, economic, and domestic spheres, with a high degree of relational redundancy and cross-referencing. At Elkab, by contrast, funerary inscriptions, stelae, and tomb architecture foreground elite self-representation, kinship memory, and localized authority (Davies 2010; Davies 2024). The resulting networks are more selective, emphasising lineage continuity and commemorative ties rather than institutional embeddedness.

Combining prosopography with historical network analysis, the study integrates heterogeneous datasets through relational modeling that distinguishes between bureaucratic, kinship, and commemorative ties. The comparison demonstrates that differences in network density, clustering, and centrality are not only reflections of historical reality but also effects of source affordances. Administrative archives generate highly connected, multiplex networks, while funerary corpora produce sparser, lineage-oriented structures with stronger narrative coherence.

These findings highlight the epistemological implications of working with uneven datasets. Fragmentation and selective visibility emerge as analytically productive conditions that shape both the scale and the type of connectivity that can be observed. Rather than normalising or compensating for these differences, the study proposes a comparative framework that treats source-specific biases as integral to historical interpretation.

By situating Egyptian evidence within broader debates in historical network research, the paper contributes to methodological discussions on data integration, comparability, and the role of media in structuring social knowledge. It demonstrates that ancient Egyptian sources, when approached through a critical network perspective, offer a particularly clear case of how

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different documentary regimes condition the reconstruction of past social worlds.

References

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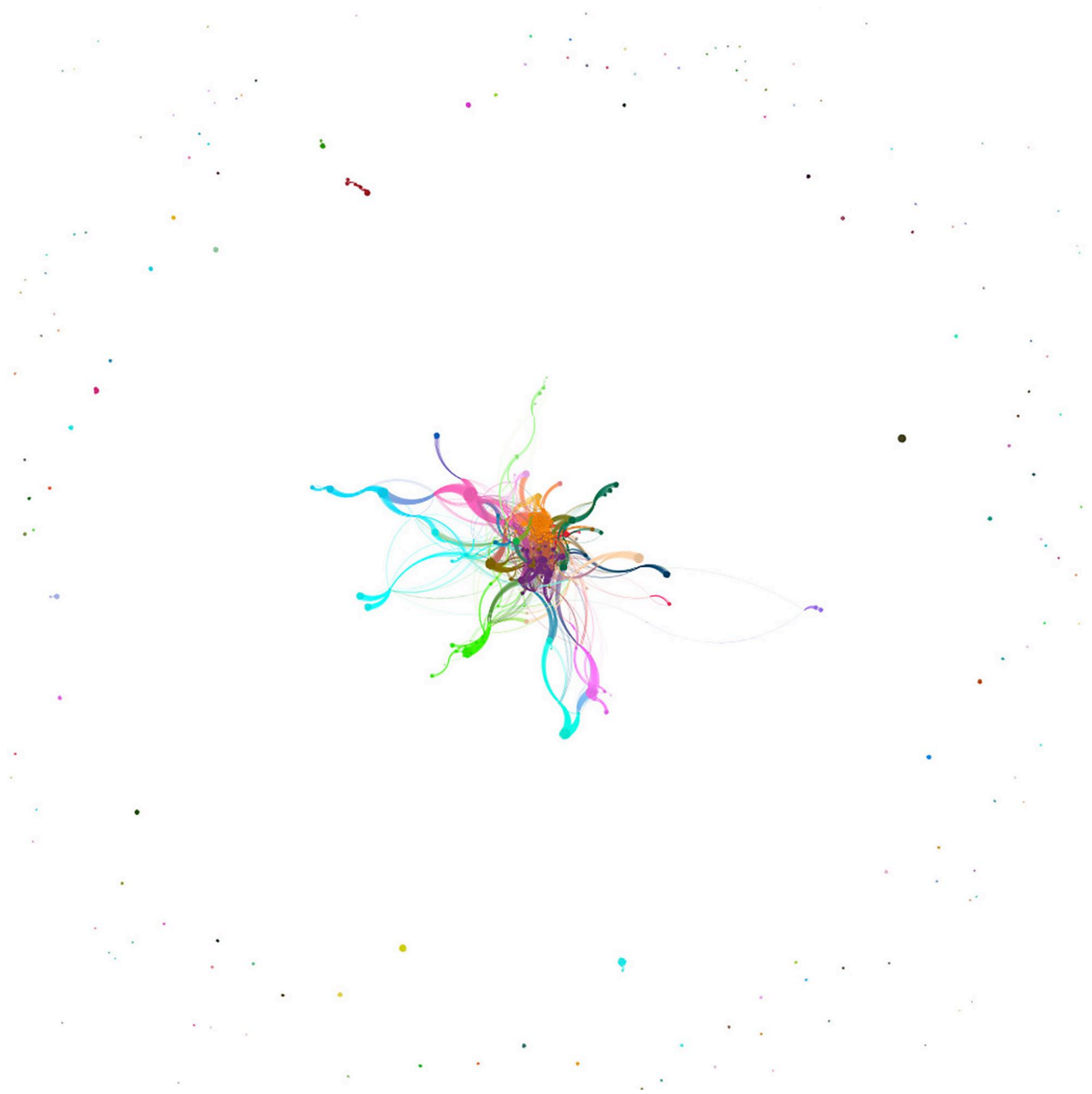


Fig. 1 Directed 1-mode network of the Lahun settlement community. Network size: 3768 nodes connected by 59456 non-filtered edges. Node colour: modularity. Node size (degree). Layout: Fruchterman-Reingold algorithm. Graph created in Gephi.

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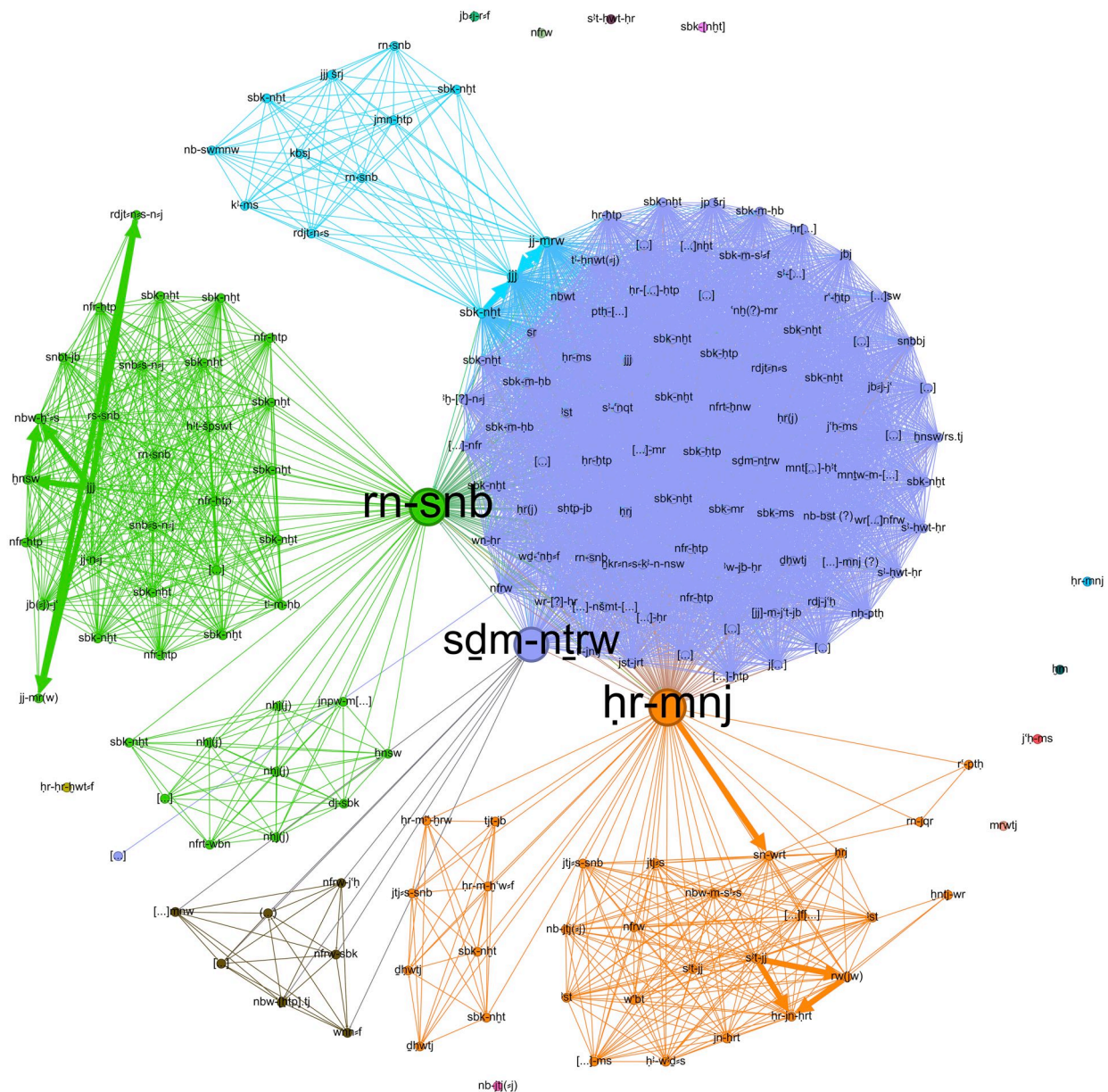


Fig. 2 Directed 1-mode network of the Elkab necropolis community. Network size: 187 nodes connected by 4857 non-filtered edges. Node colour: modularity (14 clusters). Node size (degree). Layout: Fruchterman-Reingold algorithm. Graph created in Gephi.